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Note on George Nidever

A "Clean-Living and Upright" Trapper

By VIRGINIA THOMSON

IN HIS "Answer to One Reader's Complaint about *The Big Sky*," William Sloane, the book's original publisher, made the following statement from New York City in 1947, with regard to Alfred B. Guthrie:

The purpose of the author has been to show that in living and acting as they did (hunters and trappers), they destroyed the wilderness, which was the only thing they really loved. I don't see how the author could have written the story—and it is a very moral story—that he wanted to tell if his hero had been a clean-living, upright man. There weren't any clean-living, upright men engaged in despoiling the American wilderness at that time.

The purpose of the present article is to point out that there was at least one "clean-living, upright man" engaged in trapping at that time, namely, George Nidever, a native of Tennessee, whose experiences in "despoiling [?] the American wilderness" did not interfere with his becoming, and remaining, a respected citizen of Santa Barbara for half a century.

As a young man, not wishing to pursue the comparatively static life of a farmer like his father, George Nidever had chosen the opposite one of hunting and trapping. While out after beaver with a party under Col. Robert Bean in 1830-33, he explored areas that are now parts of New Mexico, Wyoming, Montana, and Idaho.

Nidever was no common trapper. He was a marksman of such great ability that companies of trappers were said to have bet as high as \$5,000 that Nidever could kill more buffalo than any other man in the Rocky Mountains. While he was living in California, he became renowned as a grizzly bear hunter; according to reports, he killed more than 200. Sea otters on the coast of California succumbed to his marksmanship to the recorded number of 1091, between the years 1835 and 1848.¹ Even when he was in his seventies, his skill did not desert him. On September 1, 1878, E. F. Murray, an assistant of Hubert Howe Bancroft, visited

Nidever in the vicinity of Santa Barbara and took down his autobiography; he also wrote a description of him at 75 years of age:

The subject of this sketch. . . is still strong and active. He is about the medium height and inclined to be stout. He stoops the least bit but it may be from habit rather than old age. His sight and hearing are still keen and his nerves remarkably steady for one so old. He lives with his youngest daughter and his wife, about a mile from town, on a piece of land containing several acres. It is under cultivation and he keeps it free from squirrels by shooting them with a Colt's revolver. If a chicken is wanted for dinner he prefers shooting its head off with his rifle to using a shot gun, which he has frequently to use, however, owing to the danger of using his rifle when there are so many and near neighbors.²

Murray induced Nidever to shoot three shots at a paper target, three inches square, hanging on a nail some sixty yards away. All three shots landed on the paper, the second shot hitting the nail. Nidever used a muzzle-loader in a resting position.

William Henry Ellison speaks of another merit that Nidever had as a trapper; this was a "remarkable ability to recognize different Indian tribes and to remember their location."³ As will be seen later, his shrewdness on one occasion saved his own and others' lives.

Physical difficulties never seemed to bother Nidever. While he was with Colonel Bean's party, dense timberlands were encountered and 12 to 16 inches of snow in the mountain gorges of Wyoming. After six days without food, Nidever shot and killed two buffalo bulls. The men were so hungry that they continued to eat the flesh of one bull all night, until six o'clock the next morning. According to Job Dye, a member of the party, ". . . they would skin a small piece and cut off a chunk of meat and throw it into the fire, and there let it remain until it became black and charred, when it was taken from the smoking blaze and eaten, almost as raw as when it was alive in the buffalo hide."⁴

In his own account and in the accounts of others who knew him, I have been unable to find that George Nidever used any obscene language or profanity, or that he was disrespectful toward God and man. He killed Indians only in self-defense, and not for scalps. Nor did he steal horses and boats.

He lived among the toughest of men, but he was not like them in his morals. An example of one of these "toughest of men" was Isaac Graham, whom Theodore H. Hittell describes as "a man entirely without education," but possessed of "enterprise and intelligence" and "a considerable amount of personal magnetism."⁵ He was a close companion

of Nidever at first. But their friendship ceased when Graham became leader of a motley crew, who helped put Alvarado in office and then sought to take abusive advantage of the governor.

In 1844-1845, when José Castro joined in a revolt to drive Gov. Manuel Micheltorena out of California, Nidever refused to join the latter's foreign company. Even though he favored Micheltorena, Nidever had his scruples: many of the soldiers were freed convicts, and the characters of officers and regulars questionable.

There was one incident in Nidever's life, of which he repented later. While with Colonel Bean's company in 1830, "below the mouth of the Cimarron,"⁶ Nidever started out with Isaac Graham to get buffalo. They walked a full four miles from camp before they came upon any, and, when they did, the two men, being on foot, had no trouble in approaching unnoticed. But they realized that they had walked into a trap when 80 armed Arapaho Indians appeared from nowhere and began chasing them. The nearest timber was fully a mile and a half away, over by the river. They started running for their lives. Graham, the better athlete, could have left Nidever in the rear, but "it was not his character to desert a comrade in danger."⁷ Not until nearly a mile of ground had been covered did their pursuers catch up with the white men; then, to their surprise, the Indians threw down their own guns and proceeded to give the two men a rough shaking. By signs, Nidever and Graham made them understand that there were 80 men in the camp of the white men — a slight exaggeration.⁸ This scheme had its desired effect, for the Indians spared the white men's lives and even accompanied them back to their camp. As will be seen, it didn't take long for the Arapahoes to realize that they had been tricked.

Colonel Bean decided to send out six men to look for winter quarters and game, and, when volunteers were asked for, Isaac Graham, George Nidever, James Basey, Mark Nidever (George's younger brother), Job Dye, and Frederick Christ were selected.⁹ The six traveled about 60 miles before they found a beautiful valley, apparently made-to-order for a winter camp, in the vicinity of the Arkansas River. Mark Nidever and Frederick Christ were sent back to inform the main company and guide them to the location. Meanwhile the other four set to work killing buffalo and curing the meat for the winter. According to Dye, "In four days time we had killed and hung up seventeen buffalo and covered them with hides; also a large grizzly bear."¹⁰ The meat was suspended beyond reach of wild animals, and the men then moved their camp to

a place on the side of the mountain, whence they could watch the meat and the valley below without being seen themselves.

On the fifth day, late in the evening, George Nidever felt uneasy about the meat and decided to take a stroll outside camp. Carrying his rifle with him, he walked about 400 yards before he saw that a war party of about 80 Arapahoes¹¹ were stealing the buffalo and bear meat. He reported his findings to his companions, and all agreed to abandon camp and look for Colonel Bean's main company. When they reached it, the first thing that greeted Nidever was the news that the two men sent back — his brother Mark, and Frederick Christ — had been killed by the Indians. They had reached camp in safety and were acting the part of guides for the return journey, when they met the 75 to 80 Arapahoes who had been stealing the buffalo meat. The main company knew that the two men had reached the place selected for winter-quarters, because they found their names cut in the bark of a log on which they had sat before being taken captive.¹² Their captors were the same Arapahoes who had chased George Nidever and Isaac Graham; realizing that they had been tricked, the Indians had taken revenge on two men not at all connected with the original deception. Later on, George met some Mexicans. He recognized that one of them had his brother's gun. When questioned, the man revealed that the Indians had sold Mark's gun to him, and Christ's to another member of the Mexican party. Also gleaned was the fact that Mark had killed three of the Indians before they killed him.

Nidever said of his brother that he "... was one of the best men we had in our company — active, strong, hardy, brave, and a good shot. He was missed and mourned by all."¹³

Nidever could not shake the picture of his brother's death from his mind. Three years afterward, he was a member of Capt. Joseph Reddelford Walker's party — the first party known to have crossed the Sierra Nevada going west into California. Just after entering the mountains, Captain Walker chose George Nidever and Zenas Leonard to help him select a camping-place. They decided to take different routes. It was not long before Nidever discovered fresh signs of Indians. Alarmed not only for his own safety, but also for the safety of Walker and Leonard, he was looking around for more signs, when he happened to turn in the direction from which he had come and saw two Indians trotting along the trail, with their heads down. It was evident that they had seen Leon-

ard and Walker and had fled from the scene, for every few yards they would stop, look back, and listen as if pursued.

At first Nidever thought that they were following his own tracks, and, going behind a tree, he prepared to meet them. But the Indians were not even aware that he existed, for they passed in single file a few feet from him, conversing as they went. He decided to let them go; then the brutal mangling of his brother came to his mind: ". . . watching my chance, just before they would have to turn around a small point of rocks, I fired, shooting both of them dead at the first shot." Zenas Leonard says that Nidever killed the Indians because he thought that they had already attacked Walker and him; that Nidever was sorry when he found out his mistake.

In describing Nidever's character, E. F. Murray, Bancroft's assistant, wrote: "He is quite unassuming and never brags of his feats of skill, and almost everything of this nature relating to him I first learned from others, obtaining a recital of them from him only by dint of questioning. His truthfulness and integrity are beyond question, so that great weight should be given to all he says."¹⁶

Other trappers' lives could be cited, which would go far in refuting the charges Publisher Sloane made in his "Answer . . .," as quoted in the opening paragraph of this paper. Three such individuals were Job Francis Dye, Zenas Leonard, and Allen Light (otherwise known as Black Steward — the man appointed by Governor Alvarado in 1839, to prevent illegal otter hunting in California).¹⁷

NOTES

1. These figures are based on references found in Nidever's autobiography, "Life and Adventures of George Nidever, a Pioneer of California since 1834," hereafter cited as Nidever's Narrative (manuscript, Bancroft Library), pp. 5-6. See also H. H. Bancroft, *History of Nevada, Colorado and Wyoming* (San Francisco, 1890), p. 42; and his *History of California* (San Francisco, 1886), IV, 753.

2. Nidever's Narrative, p. 3.

3. William Henry Ellison, *The Life and Adventures of George Nidever* (Berkeley, 1937), 93, note 15.

4. Job Francis Dye, "Recollections of California," hereafter cited as Dye's Recollections (manuscript, Bancroft Library), p. 10. This manuscript was dictated to Thomas Savage by Dye in 1877.

5. Theodore Henry Hittell, *History of California* (San Francisco, 1885-1897), II, 266.

6. Dye's Recollections, p. 4.
7. Nidever's Narrative, p. 22.
8. There were 43 men in the trapping party.
9. Nidever's Narrative, p. 28; Dye's Recollections, p. 5.
10. Dye's Recollections, p. 6.
11. *Ibid*; Nidever's Narrative, p. 30. Dye says "about 75 Snake Indians"—they were more likely Arapaho, as may be seen from the account which follows.
12. Nidever's Narrative, pp. 30-32; Dye's Recollections, pp. 6-9.
13. Nidever's Narrative, p. 32.
14. *Ibid.*, p. 61.
15. W. F. Wagner, ed., *Narrative of the Adventures of Zenas Leonard* (Cleveland, 1904), pp. 168-69.
16. Nidever's Narrative, p. 4.
17. H. H. Bancroft, *History of the Northwest Coast* (San Francisco, 1884), II, 604-607. See also Alvarado to Light, Santa Barbara, Jan. 27, 1839 (San Diego Archives, in Bancroft Library, p. 218).